The Downward Spiral

Judges 2:6–23 · Judges 6–8 · Judges 13–16

The big idea: Within one generation Israel forgot the LORD, and the days of the judges became a downward spiral of sin, trouble, crying out, and rescue. God rescued them again and again out of pity, through flawed judges who could not change their hearts.

Before you meet: Read

Judges 2:6–23 | Judges 7:1–22 | Judges 8:22–27

Open (5 minutes)

Who passed faith on to you, or who do you wish had? What made the difference?

Observe (fill in from the passage)

"And there arose another _____ after them who did not know the LORD or the work that he had done for Israel." *(Judges 2:10)*

"For the LORD was moved to _____ by their groaning because of those who afflicted and oppressed them." *(Judges 2:18)*

"I will not rule over you, and my son will not rule over you; the _____ will rule over you." *(Judges 8:23)*

Discuss

1. Judges 2:10 describes a generation that did not know the LORD. How can faith be lost in a single generation? What guards against it? *Judges 2:10; Deuteronomy 6:7*

2. Where do you see the cycle of Judges in your own life: sin, trouble, crying out, rescue, and back again? *Judges 2:11–19*

3. Gideon said, "the LORD will rule over you," and then made an ephod that became a snare. How can a good start go wrong? *Judges 8:22–27*

Memory verse

"And I am sure of this, that he who began a good work in you will bring it to completion at the day of Jesus Christ."

Philippians 1:6

Pray

Name to God the sin you keep returning to. Thank him for his pity and patience, and ask him to change your heart and not only rescue you from trouble.

LEADER NOTES · WEEK 25

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Session plan (about 45 minutes)

5 min	Welcome, opening prayer, and the Open question.
10 min	Read Judges 2:11–19 and 7:2–8 aloud together.
5 min	Observe: work through the fill-ins together. Use the answer key below.
20 min	Discuss: choose three of the questions.
5 min	Pray together. Introduce the memory verse and next week's reading (Judges 21:25 and the book of Ruth).

Main points to land

1. Faith can be lost in one generation. Judges begins with children who did not know the LORD (Judges 2:10), the opposite of Deuteronomy 6:7.
2. Judges is a downward spiral of sin, trouble, groaning, and rescue. God disciplined Israel and, moved by compassion, rescued them again and again (Judges 2:11–19).
3. The judges were flawed rescuers. They saved for a while but could not change hearts. Israel needed a better Rescuer (Judges 2:18–19; 8:27).

Answer key (Observe)

1. generation
2. pity
3. LORD

Questions people will ask

If Gideon and Samson did such terrible things, why does Hebrews 11 list them as heroes of faith?
Hebrews honors their faith, not their whole lives. God works through weak and sinful people who trust him, even a little, and Samson's last act was a cry to the LORD (Judges 16:28). Their failures show why Israel needed a better rescuer, and why we do too.

Closing prayer

Father, we see ourselves in Israel's cycle: forgetting you, falling, crying out, and forgetting again. Thank you that you are moved to pity by our groaning. Thank you for Jesus, the Rescuer who changes hearts and finishes what he begins. Amen.